Teaching academic literacies

Do I teach the literacies students need?

LANGUAGE / CURRICULUM

ONE-PAGE TEACHING GUIDE

WHAT IS IT?

Language and literacy development is a core curriculum responsibility, scaffolded rather than assumed

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

University contains many hidden rules: what “critical analysis” means, what a rubric is really asking for, when it is acceptable to ask for help, or what counts as “professional” behaviour. If those rules remain unspoken, familiarity can be mistaken for capability.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “Everyone else seems to know rules nobody has explained.”
- “I understand the topic, but not what I am being asked to do.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Treat reading, writing, speaking and disciplinary interpretation as teachable parts of the course.
- Sequence those literacies over time instead of assuming students already know them.
- Avoid framing support as remedial for only some students.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A first-year program explicitly teaches how to read disciplinary texts and use evidence rather than assuming these skills at entry.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

This course has been designed to teach the academic and disciplinary literacies students need to complete the learning successfully. If you notice an avoidable barrier or an important perspective that is missing, tell us…

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